The Amish Project

By Jessica Dickey

Characters:
Carol: Widow of the gunman
Eddie: The gunman
Sherry: A non-Amish community member
Anna: One of the slain schoolgirls
Velda: 6-years old; one of the slain schoolgirls.

INTRODUCTION

Grief and guilt follow the survivors of any tragedy. None of us can bring back the victims of the Murrah Building bombing in Oklahoma City or the World Trade Center or the stolen lives of five murdered children in a Pennsylvania schoolhouse in 2006. Nothing can erase the horrible experience of the five girls who survived that day.

At 10:25 a.m. on October 2, 2006, a gunman entered an Amish one-room schoolhouse in the Old Order Amish community of Nickel Mines, PA. Forty minutes later, he shot ten young girls, killing five, then turned the gun on himself. What occurred in the wake of this tragedy stunned the nation. How do you forgive the unforgivable?

The Amish Project by Jessica Dicky is an unforgettable account of the Nickel Mines shooting and its aftermath, seen through the eyes of multiple characters.

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CAROL: **(Pg 12-13)** I was in the grocery store this morning and it occurred to me for the first time . . . I was in the hygiene aisle or whatever, trying to find a moisturizer with the um, SPF or whatever . . . No one tells you that even when you're mourning, you still worry about wrinkles. So now you know. So I'm reading the labels about the UVA and the UVB and wham! Just like that. I think, Just because it's written on the label *doesn't mean it's true.* Something can be written down, FDA approved, FBI protected, and that doesn't make it true.

You can put your hand on a Bible and swear to tell the truth, and still lie. The *Bible*. And then you think, well what is the Bible? How is that any different from the bright yellow

words on the cover of my Advil that says "Eliminates pain"? The Bible: "Proof of God." Really?

Think of the sickest thing you've ever read. Right now. Do it. It was true, wasn't it? It was something that really happened. What happens to a person when you live in a world where you can't believe anything, and the things you don't want to believe are actually true?

You can swear right in front of everyone you have ever know that this person – this person before you – is The One. You promise to stand by them and love them, and nurse them – Right there – cheap tux, white dress, swear in front of your family and friends. Don't make it true.

(Pg 15) *(as newscaster)* This just in! Widow of crazed schoolhouse gunman buys a lotion with an SPF. Here at the BS Channel we have the exclusive interview. Now Carol Stuckey, why did you choose a lotion with an SPF? *(as herself)* Well, Craig, I realized if I'd taken better care of my skin and prevented wrinkles from my face, maybe my husband wouldn't have tried to molest little Amish girls *(pause)* *(as newscaster)* Uh huh, and how do you like the SPF lotion so far? *(as herself)* Oh, it's awesome.

SHERRY: **(Pg 18-20)** We moved to Nickel Mines about 20 years ago. We have a little farm 'bout 4 miles out of town. On October 2nd, 2006, I read the headline across CNN – Man Enters Amish Schoolhouse And Opens Fire. They kept showing these images over and over again. It was a birds eye view: Amish families gathering in a green field, The white ambulances with red lights circles around the white schoolhouse. Tiny rectangles of bodies covered in sheets. Then the shocking details began to emerge. This just in: He was the local milkman. He only shot the girls. At least three dead. White ambulances. White schoolhouse. Bodies covered in sheets. He intended to molest them. He shot himself. Death toll now six. This just in: The Amish request that the medical condition of the remaining girls be withheld. They extend forgiveness to the gunman. They extend condolences to the gunman's family. Green field. White. Red. White. I thought – What kind of SICKO could do this???!

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CAROL: **(Pg 20-21)** The boys seem kind of numb. I sometimes think ***they're*** the ones who are dead. Little ghosts. I keep my expectations low. That they sit at the table and eat their cereal, that's enough. That somehow I managed to put two bowls, two spoons, a box of Frosted Flakes, that's Joshy's favorite, a box of Cocoa Puffs, that's Jeremy's favorite, on the table with milk, and they sit and eat it, and somehow get out the door to the carpool for the sitters, is a miracle to me. A total miracle. That's a laugh – I'm talkin' about miracles. You wanna hear a miracle? I still love my husband . . . I miss him. **(Pg 27)** He wrote: "Dear Carol. I'm sorry that I won't see the boys grow up. You're a good mother and I know it will be hard for you now. I hope you can forgive me for that. Please understand and try to forgive me. Tell the boys that I love 'em. Tell 'em – I wasn't all bad."

SHERRY: **(Pg 28)** If you were a decent wife those poor girls would be alive today.

CAROL: Some woman came up to me in the grocery store, perfectly normal looking woman came up to me . . . put her cart next to my cart and said, If you were a decent wife those poor girls would be alive today. She said:

SHERRY: There is a fresh hell where you'll join your SICKO husband.

CAROL: And for some reason I laughed. Oh, I ran to the parking lot, smeared moisturizer over my face, scratched myself over and over again. But in the moment I laughed. You do things like that when you're losin' your mind. **(Pg 30)** It was the word. Sicko. Sicko. Sicko. Sicko. **(Pg 33)** There's a fresh hell where you'll join your sicko husband. I'm sure she's right.

SHERRY: **(Pg 18)** Man Enters Amish Schoolhouse And Opens Fire. . . . **(Pg 33)** Oh, I ain't proud of it, but come on now, you was thinkin' it too. You been seein' it on the news – these pitchers of the schoolhouse and the Amish in their buggies, but to be here, where it all happened, and see those poor people . . . Believe me, I ain't never said somethin' so mean in my entire life. But all day I'd been watchin' the news and feelin' so sick 'n' sad, and I saw her there in the grocery store, and somethin' just snapped. **(Pg 34)** Don't get me wrong – I ain't exactly stickin' up for the Amish, but we gotta draw the line somewhere. I mean, can you imagine – Oh, that's alright, Sicko! You just go right ahead, do whatever you want, we'll

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FORGIVE YA. What's that say to all the other Sickos?!! And don't tell me a WIFE don't know SOMETHIN' like THAT!

EDDIE: **(Pg 35)** I used to watch 'em while I did my rounds. You ever seen 'em? I mean, a whole flock of 'em – in a field or crossing the road? Their little legs in their stockings, and the little bib things they wear, the way their hair twists up and disappears into their little bonnets . . . it's like – all that beauty, all that pink, tucked away under there, hidden. Like a clean secret. They sort of scatter as you come near. But once in a while if you wave, one of 'em will wave back *(Eddie waves to Anna)*

ANNA: *(waves back)* **(Pg 36-37)** He came into the school while Miss Emma was preparing the blackboard for a spelling exercise. He has a gun. He makes the boys leave and Miss Emma leave. He barricades the front door. He tells the girls to line up along the chalk board. There are ten of us. He ties our wrists with plastic ties, and our feet. I started praying to God, trying to feel how God would want me to behave – but my heart is racing. The police are pulling up around the school. Everything is getting louder and louder. Sweat pours down his face. We are lined up against the chalkboard, wanting our mammas. Waiting. **(Pg 38)** Sir, please shoot me first!

EDDIE: I wanted to have the girls! But the police arrived real fast – I don't know how – so fast – I didn't get to have the girls. So I shot 'em.

ANNA: Sir, please shoot me first!

EDDIE: I shot 'em! Each one. In the head. Then I shot myself.

VELDA: *(singing and Amish hymn)* O, God our Father/ O, Open me / With your love / Teach me to forgive / With your love.

CAROL: Got back from the store and the Amish were here. Spent all morning with me. There were about five of 'em here, huddled here together in the living room. **(Pg 39)** The women wear those bonnets and cotton dresses, and the men have the blue shirts with suspenders and hats, like another planet. **(Pg 41)** They brought food. They were very polite. They kept deferring to me, to my grief. I wanted to say, stop. Stop. **(Pg 42-43)** I asked [them] how they were, how [their] little girls were. And [they] looked at me and said *(gently taking on*

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another voice) "We must trust in God now. *(back to her own voice)* Is that right? Trust in God. Have you turned on the TV lately? Oh you haven't? You don't believe in TV? Well isn't that nice for you. Lemme fill you in: Shit like this happens every day. And the scary thing is, as mortified as I am by my husband's actions – Eddie wasn't a bad guy. He wasn't the Devil. He just couldn't keep his darkness down anymore, and it ate him. It ate him and those poor little girls, and now it's eating me. And you can say that's Evil, but the truth is – that's all of us. That's the world. We're all just a few bad days from SICKO and that's not Satan, that's the truth. It lives in me and yes, it lives in you. And if you God is so great, then where was HE?!!! Where was your God when my husband took three guns, and plastic ties and drove over to Stultz Road?

VELDA: **(Pg 46)** *(Drawing on a chalkboard)* This is Anna, with her pretty pink lips. These are the ties on her wrists and feet. And the bullet. **(Pg 48)** This is Anna's best friend, Marian. **(Pg 49)** This is my best friend Emma. She has red hair and she can hold her breath a LONG time. *(She continues to draw each girl)* This is Margaret – Um – She has the weirdest teeth. **(Pg 50)** This is Catherine. She's a great singer. This is Elizabeth who talks ALL THE TIME, and her little sister Mary. Who never talks at all. And this is Dottie. She snorts when she laughs. And then – there's Little Esther.

CAROL: **(Pg 9)** Man Enters Amish Schoolhouse And Opens Fire.

VELDA: **(Pg 50-51)** *(Velda counts down the line of her drawings of the girls, pointing at each one, like a gunshot . . .)* One! Two! Three! Four! Five! Six! Seven! Eight! NINE! *(She takes her place inside her drawing, holding her wrists and feet as if they're bound)* Ten. *(She looks intently at the audience)* Can you see Him? He's here. God is here. Can you see Him? Can you see Him? Keep looking.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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